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Zande blood-brotherhood

Author(S): Evans-Pritchard, E. E. (Edward Evan)**Document Type:** Book Chapter**Original Page:** 394**Culture (OWC):** [Azande \(F007\)](#)**Region:** Africa**Sub Region:** Central Africa**Field Date:** 1926-1929**Coverage Date:** 1926-1929**Place Coverage**

Nili-Uelle Divide, Democratic Republic of the Congo

Section Title(S): Untitled Section

"It sometimes happens that one observes flagrant breaches of the obligations of blood-brotherhood. I came across one instance of a man who committed adultery with the wife of his blood-brother and an instance of another who tried to do so. But such cases are, I am convinced, rare, though less rare to-day than in past times. People are undoubtedly very frightened of the consequences of failure to carry out their duties and one constantly hears Azande remark that 'Blood is no joke, it is a very serious matter.' A man does not enter lightly into an alliance, and in my experience people have the best intentions to fulfil their obligations. It was not long, however, before I began to observe that the Zande often tries to avoid fulfilling his obligations towards his blood-brother if he finds them irksome in the same way as he tries to wriggle out of his obligations towards his relatives and to other persons to whom he is supposed to act in certain ways. At the same time he protests vigorously his good faith. He would not make a deliberate breach of the pact, but the idea of reciprocity on which it is based gives ample scope for grumbling and for withholding gifts on the grounds that one's partner has done the same. In this respect blood-brotherhood displays the same opposition of egoism to social duties which is characteristic of other groups and associations in human culture. "

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755 Prospect Street

New Haven, CT 06511

General Inquiries:  hraf@yale.edu

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